complex configuration, as well as some duplication of effort between the configuration of the tool and configuration of external JavaScript and CSS tooling. These tools handled both JavaScript and CSS in a way that was often confusing. Over time, the plain fact that these were smaller tools continually playing catchup with the entire JavaScript ecosystem caused additional problems.

The Rails 7 tools allow you to use your choice of external JavaScript and CSS builders—all you need to do is configure those external tools to output their built files to a known location. The JavaScript Bundling for Rails (jsbundling-rails) tool coordinates JavaScript tooling via your choice of esbuild, Rollup, or webpack (we're using esbuild in this book). The CSS Bundling for Rails (cssbundling-rails) tool allows you to use Tailwind, PostCSS, or Sass (we're using Tailwind). Once the files are in the known location, we use Propshaft to serve them to the browser. Alternately, you can use the importmap-rails gem to manage JavaScript with no build step at all.

From the Rails perspective, these tools are much simpler—there's really not much to the bundling tools beyond installation and a couple of Rake tasks. They are also much more flexible against new tooling arising in the front-end world.

In this chapter, we'll look at what all these tools do and why they are the way they are. We'll also look at the external tools they support and how to use them.